

the youth? Not even the latest version of Brand Gandhi, it seems.

The current IYC worker is best exemplified by the Jagat Singh (Natwar Singh's son) prototype of fast cars, foreign junkets and scandals. A former IYC leader says, "During Randip Surjewala's time (2000-2005), IYC operated between Delhi's 5, Rajendra Prasad Road (its headquarters) and Jantar Mantar, where the bulk of public demonstrations took place. In current IYC chief Ashok Tanwar's era, the focus has shifted to auditoriums, workshops and seminars. Street fights and social work play a token role."

One thing remains the same though. IYC's perennial pastime, landing outside the Gandhi-heir-of-the-moment's house with a cake on his birthday. In a party where dynasty has replaced democracy, sycophancy is a shrewd career move. An IYC leader rues that the prominence given to the band of young MPs—each of who is also a young dynast—has discouraged grassroots workers, who feel that with leadership being parachuted from the top, it makes little sense to politick at the street level. It is up to Rahul Gandhi to inspire his team and dispel this feeling of neglect. After all, his father and uncle played with the same dynastic card. But, unlike Sanjay or even Rajiv Gandhi, who used the youth wing to counter V.P. Singh and the Bofors allegations, Rahul is a reluctant leader. Playing cricket with NSUI and IYC members may foster great team spirit but when does the leadership quotient come in? Bringing Sam Pitroda in to help with the youth wing is also not the right answer. "I feel the youth are distancing themselves from politics. They want to have direct access to the leaders," admits Rahul. Earlier IYC chiefs like Dasmunshi, Soni, Azad had direct access to both Indira

and Sanjay. In the age of Special Protection Group security, this access to leaders is limited.

The BJP youth wing, too, suffers from a lack of direction from the top leadership. The Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha chief, Amit Thakkar, says he is trying to bring back the focus on grassroots level programmes such as protests against the UPA's lapses in internal security and the reservation policy. But these are sporadic efforts to grab the leadership's eye. Most of the time it is just winking in the dark. In true BJP *chintan baithak* style, national leaders address youth wing seminars, offering rhetoric but little direction.



TOKEN PROTESTS RATHER THAN MASS MOVEMENTS TYPIFY TODAY'S YOUTH POLITICS.

"You cannot just blame the young. It is the leadership that has to provide the vision," says Yadav. Moreover, today, with each and every political party having been in power at some point or the other, no leader has an anti-establishment appeal any more. Even Karat and Yechury, who personified a cause for young revolutionaries, have lost their rebel appeal. This year, after nearly a decade, SFI lost all the four seats in the JNU students' elections. The issue that raged the campus was not Trotsky but Nandigram. The group that won was the pro-Naxalite All India Students' Association (AISA). "Free market is now the new ideology, even the

communists are part of the Government that promotes this," says 25-year-old Sandeep Singh, JNU students' union president. The last time a student protest caught the nation's eye was probably when Rajeev Goswami set himself on fire to protest against the Mandal Commission report in 1990. Today when reservation finds its way back into political jargon once again, there is little protest even against the inclusion of creamy layer. In the DU student polls this year, the only party that came out against reservations was a non-political outfit.

"The students are not to blame for lack of 'movemental' approach to issues," says D.P. Tripathi, NCP leader and a former JNU union president. Perhaps a reflection of the national scene, university elections too are no longer driven by rhetoric and ideology, but instead by money and muscle power. For instance, of the past 10 presidents of the Lucknow University, eight face criminal cases. Delhi's Jamia Millia University was closed down last year after a group of students protested violently against the vice-chancellor's decision not to admit students with a criminal record. The J.M.

Lyngdoh Committee report of May 2006, that looked into the revamp of campus elections, cites the case of Lucknow University saying student leaders "have their own gunmen and coerce college principals". This is today's brand of campus politics from where tomorrow's leaders will graduate, *magna cum laude*.

The onus is on yesterday's youth leaders to once again bring back the fire into the politics of the young. Otherwise the only political movement will be from the Youth Congress office to 10 Janpath or from the BJP headquarters to the nearest seminar room.

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